

Design Research for an Environmental Impact App Inspired by Kurzgesagt and Duolingo

The strongest takeaway

Kurzgesagt and Duolingo both make complicated subjects feel friendly, but they do so with different emphases. Kurzgesagt builds *wonder* around science through vibrant vector illustration, animation, optimism, and an explicitly aesthetic, fun, accessible point of view; it also says its work aims to be objective, rigorous, and self-aware. Duolingo builds *clarity and habit* through bite-sized tasks, gamified feedback, bold rounded visuals, and a brand system built around a small set of shapes, a strong green accent, and a highly consistent voice. ¹

For your app, the right move is not a literal 50/50 merge. Use **Duolingo for interaction grammar** and **Kurzgesagt for atmosphere and scientific storytelling**. In practice, that means Duolingo should dominate buttons, hierarchy, spacing, state feedback, and friendliness, while Kurzgesagt should dominate the scene-building, illustration mood, layered backgrounds, and the sense that environmental data belongs to a living world rather than a flat dashboard. That split fits your subject much better than copying either site wholesale. ²

Kurzgesagt design language

Kurzgesagt's own site and about pages are unusually explicit about its worldview. It says its mission is to make science and humanism appealing to as many people as possible, its values are "aesthetic, fun and accessible," and the feeling it wants to instill is optimism. That matters because the site's visual language is not just decorative; it is a delivery mechanism for scientific curiosity. The core emotional tone is **playful seriousness**: rigorous content, but never sterile. ³

Visually, the homepage and related pages lean hard into **big-scene composition**. The homepage uses a space background with stars, a central Earth illustration, decorative star-line animation elements, and animated rockets with engine flames. The "Who we are" page continues with a space-themed background, gradient overlays, stars, clouds, and line-and-dot decorative elements. The "What we do" page adds abstract scientific patterns, blurred gradient overlays, and an animated amoeba illustration. In other words, Kurzgesagt does not place content on neutral containers first and decorate later; it builds a *world* first and lets text live inside it. ⁴

Its process page also explains the visual stack behind that feeling. Kurzgesagt says it uses vector illustration, pixel-based illustration, and infographics to create its playful style; it calls quirky, relatable characters one of its trademarks; and for motion it combines classic 2D flat animation with 3D elements as needed. That combination explains why the brand reads as both clean and crafted: shapes are simple, but scenes feel layered and authored rather than generic. ⁵

A few specific traits are worth isolating for imitation:

The first is **cinematic background depth**. Even when the art is flat, there is usually a layered field of particles, gradients, glows, clouds, stars, or scientific motifs behind the main object. The second is

heroic scale contrast: very large headlines, very large illustrations, then smaller explanatory copy. The third is **micro-spectacle:** little moving flames, floating objects, pulsing stars, drifting organisms, or looping background detail. The site's alt text confirms ambient animated elements on-page; the screenshots you attached suggest that these motions are part of the experience rather than afterthoughts. ⁶

Typography on the current Kurzgesagt website appears to be a clean geometric sans with a high x-height and broad, open forms [unconfirmed from the screenshots alone; I could not verify an official web-font source]. What *is* clear is the typographic behaviour: massive headings, short subcopy, and enough surrounding negative space that illustration can carry equal emotional weight with the text. That balance is one of the main reasons the site feels alive instead of merely informative. ⁷

The implication for an environmental app is important: do **not** copy the space motif literally unless your product is about climate science in a cosmic/editorial framing. What you want from Kurzgesagt is the **editorial-science composition system:** layered scene backgrounds, optimistic intensity, beautifully simplified metaphors, and ambient motion that implies a living system.

Duolingo design language

Duolingo's official product copy and brand guidelines are much more systematised. The public site presents itself as "the free, fun, and effective way to learn a language," and its older official splash page describes lessons as bite-sized skills that feel like games, with immediate grading, rewards, and personalised adaptation. That is not just marketing copy. It is the logic behind the visual design: every screen tries to reduce friction, signal progress quickly, and keep motivation high. ⁸

The official design guidelines give unusually concrete rules. Duolingo says **Feather Bold** is used for large, brief headlines, while **DIN Next Rounded** is the secondary typeface and should not visually overpower Feather Bold. It also says **Feather Green** is the core brand colour and **Snow** is the primary background colour. Shape language is tightly constrained: official illustrations are built from three basic shapes, the rounded rectangle, the circle, and the rounded triangle. That simplicity is a big reason the brand feels coherent across app, site, illustration, and marketing. ⁹

The personality system is equally deliberate. Duolingo's voice guidelines say a consistent voice builds trust and familiarity, while tone is about "reading the room" and adapting to a user's state of mind. The Duo-specific writing guidance describes the mascot as helpful, motivating, organised, dependable, supportive, positive, emotive, and slightly awkward. That is why Duolingo feels warm rather than merely cute: its friendliness is operationalised in words, illustration, and feedback states all at once. ¹⁰

Its art style evolved in a very relevant way. Duolingo's design team says the older system used static, hard-edged shapes on light gray backgrounds, then shifted toward brighter, rounder, friendlier illustrations and rounded buttons on white backgrounds. It describes the resulting aesthetic as bold, bouncy, bright, minimalistic, playful, quick to produce, clear to understand, and fun to learn with. That is exactly the kind of specificity your previous prompts likely lacked. "Lighter" and "more lively" are too vague; Duolingo's actual language is about shape, background, rhythm, and attention. ¹¹

Motion is central to the brand, and this is the part you should take most seriously because you explicitly want live animation. Duolingo's design writing says animation is used to guide attention and keep learners engaged; animated skill icons increased dwell and attention on important screens. The company also describes character animations for correct answers, mid-lesson reward interstitials, and larger celebration moments such as streak milestones. Most importantly for implementation, Duolingo

says it used **Rive** because it enabled real-time interactive animation via state machines, compact file sizes, and programmatic control over animated states on web and mobile. ¹²

Duolingo's more recent design work also shows a maturing restraint. In its 2026 tab redesign, the design team explicitly balanced simplicity with clarity, reduced the number of type styles, and used whitespace more purposefully instead of wrapping everything in containers. That point is easy to miss, but it matters for your app: Duolingo is not lively because it crams in cute stuff everywhere. It is lively because it gives a few bright elements room to dominate. ¹³

What your current app is likely missing

Based on the screenshot you attached, the problem does **not** look like a simple colour problem. It looks like a **design-language specificity** problem.

What seems missing is the combination of four things that both reference sites do very well:

- **A strong shape language.** If panels and cards still read as conventional app rectangles, changing the palette will not make the interface feel more organic or alive.
- **A scene, not just a layout.** Kurzgesagt frames content inside a visual world; Duolingo frames it inside a highly intentional playful system. If your app still feels like data on a page, it will read as competent but generic.
- **Motion with purpose.** "Lively" is usually not achieved with a single hover effect. It comes from ambient loops, state transitions, small reactive physics, and celebratory feedback.
- **One emotional focal point per section.** If every section is equally flat, the page has no pulse.

My best reading of the screenshot is that your current interface still leans too far toward a standard product/dashboard feel [unconfirmed from one screenshot alone], and it is asking colour to do work that should really be done by composition, illustration, motion, and contrast in scale. That is why asking an LLM for "lighter, more natural, more lively, more creative" has not been enough. Those are outcomes. The model needed instructions about *how* to produce them.

A hybrid direction that actually fits an environmental impact product

The most effective synthesis is **Duolingo UI + Kurzgesagt atmosphere**.

That means the app should use Duolingo-like clarity for onboarding, calls to action, task flows, progress feedback, and navigational friendliness. Keep the interface readable, rounded, concise, and stateful. Use one primary action colour consistently, a rounded component library, and a very small set of repeatable interaction patterns. Let copy be short, encouraging, and human. That part is strongly aligned with Duolingo's typographic hierarchy, colour hierarchy, voice consistency, and small-shape system. ¹⁴

Then layer in Kurzgesagt where your current design appears weakest: atmosphere, science-metaphor, and environmental storytelling. Introduce serene illustrated habitats, sky or canopy gradients, floating natural particles, soft depth, and visual metaphors for climate impact, water, waste, biodiversity, and energy. Use every section as a "mini world" rather than a flat panel. Kurzgesagt's own materials repeatedly tie science communication to aesthetic accessibility, optimism, vibrant vector illustration, quirky characters, and animation. That is exactly the energy your product category can benefit from if you want it to feel hopeful rather than moralising or administrative. ¹⁵

A good environmental translation would look something like this. The background system should be **light daylight**, not dark “eco dashboard” green. Think soft cloud white, pale sky, mist, leaf tints, warm stone, muted water blue, and only one or two saturated action colours. Cards should be rounded and tactile, but not all identical. Some can feel like soft capsules, some like hill-top panels, some like instrument dials embedded in an illustrated landscape. Data should feel like part of an ecosystem: tree growth, cleaner air, restored water, reduced waste, healthier soil, returning pollinators. This is not an official rule from either brand; it is the strongest product translation of their actual design logic.

Motion should be live and layered. Duolingo is the clearest proof that interactive state-based motion scales well on the web; Kurzgesagt shows the emotional power of ambient loops and moving scenery. So your app should use a combination of **ambient motion** and **reactive motion**: gentle leaf sway, drifting seeds, bubbling water, birds crossing the hero, counters that spring upward, progress rings that bloom open, and achievement moments where a small illustrated ecosystem visibly improves. Prefer SVG, Rive, or code-driven motion over embedded video when possible. Duolingo’s own motion case studies make a strong case for real-time, controllable animation rather than passive playback. ¹⁶

Copy should stay optimistic without becoming childish. Kurzgesagt’s worldview is explicitly optimistic and humanist; Duolingo’s writing is clear, supportive, and responsive to user state. So the tone for your app should be: *encouraging, concise, grounded, and slightly playful*. Avoid guilt-heavy sustainability copy. Use language like “small changes, visible impact”, “your footprint is improving”, “this habit helps restore”, or “this week your choices saved...”. That preserves seriousness while keeping momentum.

¹⁷

A prompt you can send to an LLM with your screenshots

The prompt below is designed to fix the exact failure mode you described: vague requests for “lighter”, “more natural”, and “more lively” that produce only cosmetic changes instead of a real change in design language.

You are redesigning my environmental-impact app.

Use the attached screenshots as visual references for design language only:

- Reference A: Kurzgesagt website
- Reference B: Duolingo website
- Reference C: my current app screenshot

Important constraint:

Do NOT copy logos, mascots, exact illustrations, brand names, or proprietary assets.

Instead, extract and recreate the design grammar, motion language, layout logic, emotional tone, and interaction feel.

My current problem:

I already asked for “lighter, more natural, more lively, more creative”, but the result still feels too much like a normal SaaS/product dashboard. I need a much stronger transformation. Do not make only superficial colour tweaks. Change the actual visual system.

Target direction:

Create a hybrid design language that feels like:

- Duolingo for UI clarity, friendliness, rounded interaction patterns, motivational feedback, and strong CTA hierarchy
- Kurzgesagt for atmosphere, visual storytelling, optimistic science energy, layered illustrated scenes, and ambient motion
- Final mood: hopeful, ecological, alive, handcrafted, intelligent, playful, airy, and premium
- NOT dark dashboard
- NOT corporate ESG software
- NOT generic glassmorphism
- NOT plain card grid with a few green accents

Design goals:

The app should feel like a living environmental world, not a spreadsheet or admin panel.

Each major section should feel like a small illustrated ecosystem with motion and personality.

The interface should be bright and breathable, with one strong focal illustration or animated scene per section.

Visual system requirements:

1. Backgrounds

- Use mostly light backgrounds: warm white, mist, pale sky, soft leaf-tinted neutrals, water-blue tints
- Add subtle layered gradients and illustrated environmental depth
- Use atmospheric background details like clouds, leaves, pollen, particles, birds, water ripples, tiny stars/fireflies if relevant
- Avoid flat empty white unless balanced by illustration or motion

2. Colour palette

- Primary action colour: one clear saturated green
- Secondary accents: sky blue, river blue, sunlight yellow, soil brown, coral/orange for warnings, soft teal
- Base palette should feel natural and daylight-based, not dark forest UI
- Use saturated accents sparingly so CTAs and key states pop

3. Typography

- Headlines: bold, rounded, friendly, high-impact display style
- Body: clean, highly readable sans-serif
- Short, punchy headlines
- Strong hierarchy with oversized hero text and smaller supportive copy
- Avoid overly formal or enterprise-looking typography

4. Shape language

- Use rounded rectangles, circles, pill shapes, soft arcs, and occasional organic curves
- Components should feel soft, friendly, and tactile
- Reduce sharp corners and stiff geometry
- Some containers may have slightly custom silhouettes so the page does not feel like a template

5. Layout

- Increase whitespace significantly
- Use less uniform grid repetition
- Create stronger composition: oversized hero, illustrated side elements, asymmetrical balance, layered sections
- Do not place everything inside identical cards
- Let some sections breathe directly on the page with only selective containment

6. Illustration style

- Use simplified vector illustrations with strong silhouettes and clean grouping
- Blend Duolingo-like friendliness with Kurzgesagt-like crafted world-building
- Environmental metaphors should be visual: growing plants, cleaner rivers, healthier habitats, restored ecosystems, renewable energy, reduced waste
- Illustrations should support content, not feel like random decoration
- Build reusable SVG illustrations if assets are needed

7. Motion and animation

- Prefer live animations, not video files
- Use ambient motion loops: swaying leaves, drifting particles, floating icons, soft bobbing objects, subtle parallax, ripples, glow pulses
- Use reactive motion for interactions: springy button press, cards lifting slightly, counters ticking up, progress bars blooming open, achievement states transforming the illustration
- Add stateful celebratory feedback when goals are met
- Keep motion gentle, smart, and polished
- Respect prefers-reduced-motion

8. Data presentation

- Replace dry charts where possible with playful, readable, ecological visualisations
- Example metaphors:
 - emissions going down = cleaner sky / shrinking smoke trail
 - water saved = rising clear water / filling reservoir
 - waste reduced = cleaner habitat / fewer scattered objects
 - biodiversity action = returning birds / blooming flowers / more pollinators
- Maintain clarity and accessibility above all

9. Copy tone

- Encouraging, concise, optimistic, intelligent, slightly playful
- Avoid guilt-heavy messaging
- Avoid corporate sustainability buzzwords unless necessary
- Make progress feel rewarding and human

10. Product feeling

- The app should feel “alive” even when idle
- It should feel like an inviting educational companion
- It should encourage repeat use through delight, not pressure
- It should feel premium and custom-designed, not template-based

Implementation requirements:

- Build the redesign in production-quality code
- Use reusable design tokens for colour, radius, spacing, type scale, shadows, and motion
- Use SVG / CSS / Framer Motion / Rive-style stateful animation patterns where appropriate
- Avoid placeholder boxes and lorem ipsum visuals
- Generate actual component structure and styling
- Include hero, dashboard/home, progress modules, impact stats, challenges, achievements, and settings states
- Make the result responsive

Before writing code, do this:

1. Analyse the screenshots and explain specifically why my current UI still feels too flat / too generic / too static
2. Extract the exact design traits from Kurzgesagt and Duolingo that should be translated
3. Propose a hybrid design system for this environmental app
4. Then produce the redesigned implementation

Hard fail conditions:

- If the result still looks like a standard startup dashboard with rounded cards, you failed
- If the result only changes colours and leaves composition mostly the same, you failed
- If there is no visible illustration system, you failed
- If there is no ambient motion plan, you failed
- If it feels childish instead of warm + intelligent, you failed

Success criteria:

- brighter and more breathable
- visibly more natural and organic
- clearly more lively even at rest
- stronger emotional tone
- more custom, less template
- more story-driven, less dashboard-driven
- still highly usable and readable

Now redesign the app accordingly.

This prompt should work better because it stops the model from treating your request as a simple restyle. It forces the model to specify **shape language, motion density, illustration grammar, hierarchy, and emotional target**—the same levers both reference sites actually use. The main thing you were missing was not more adjectives. It was a much tighter description of what “alive” physically looks like in interface terms. ¹⁸

The practical rule to follow while vibecoding

If you want the app to feel closer to these references, measure every new screen against one blunt question:

Does this screen feel like a living illustrated world with clear next actions, or does it still feel like a card-based dashboard with nicer colours?

If it is the second one, keep pushing. For your category, the winning combination is not “green UI”. It is **clear motivational product design wrapped in optimistic environmental storytelling**. Duolingo proves the first half. Kurzgesagt proves the second. ¹⁹

1 3 15 17 Who we are | kurzgesagt

<https://kurzgesagt.org/who-we-are>

2 14 19 Duolingo: Learn Spanish, French and other languages for free

<https://www.duolingo.com/nojs/splash>

4 6 7 Home | kurzgesagt

<https://kurzgesagt.org/>

5 About our YouTube channel | kurzgesagt

<https://kurzgesagt.org/what-we-do?visit=videos>

8 Log in

https://www.duolingo.com/log-in?utm_source=chatgpt.com

9 Typography - Duolingo Brand Guidelines

https://design.duolingo.com/identity/typography?utm_source=chatgpt.com

10 Voice

https://design.duolingo.com/writing/voice?utm_source=chatgpt.com

11 18 Duolingo Blog

<https://blog.duolingo.com/shape-language-duolingos-art-style/>

12 Duolingo Blog

<https://blog.duolingo.com/building-character/>

13 Duolingo Blog

<https://blog.duolingo.com/core-tabs-redesign/>

16 How Duolingo Animates Its World Characters

<https://blog.duolingo.com/world-character-visemes/>